

come for talks. It must not compromise or accept any unjustified demands of these protesters. Such violent protests are akin to terrorist activities. It is high time the Maoist threat was tackled to find a permanent solution.

M. KUMAR,

via [www.indiatoday.in](http://www.indiatoday.in)

The ever-rising gap between the rich and poor and injustice to the common man by the influential lot are definitely the root causes provoking social unrest in the masses. Additionally, the sudden switch to a capitalist 'free-economy' policy from a mixed economy with a tilt towards a socialist pattern has been instrumental in widening the gap between the rich and poor. The Naxal problem that we face today has its roots in this transition.

SUBHASH AGRAWAL, Delhi

## Faded Saffron

It is true that the BJP is losing India and fast vanishing from the national mindspace ("Right in Denial", November 9). Infighting, one-upmanship, a non-secular outlook, the old not making way for the young and cheap outbursts by some of its leaders coupled with the ouster of others have weakened the party, causing sufficient harm to its image. With the absence of Atal Bihari Vajpayee at the helm, the party has

perhaps lost its flavour and people who are trying to see his shadow in L.K. Advani are somewhat disappointed.

PREM K. MENON, Mumbai

## Winning Mantra

In his essay, Prabhu Chawla has rightly analysed the pros and cons of the Maharashtra, Haryana and Arunachal Pradesh assembly elections ("The Winning Hand", November 2). The results were along ex-

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**“It is the responsibility of honest politicians to act resolutely against scams and scandals in the Indian political system, taking stringent steps to crush unscrupulous syndicates.”**

INDU SHANKAR, via [www.indiatoday.in](http://www.indiatoday.in)

pected lines. The Maharashtra elections have once again become quite predictable and only die-hard Shiv Sainiks or BJP supporters would have hoped for a miracle. But the results in Haryana came as a bit of surprise not only for the Congress but also for the Indian National Lok Dal. Chief

Minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda, who advanced the polls to cash in on his party's spectacular Lok Sabha election performance, failed miserably. However, in Arunachal Pradesh, the TMC winning a few seats may give trouble to the Congress.

BIDYUT KUMAR CHATTERJEE, Faridabad

## Time to Perform

The Maharashtra Government will have an opportunity to rule the state for

the next five years without any political threat ("Why Congress Won", November 2). Instead of touting the state's so-called prime position in the country, the chief minister and his team should start dealing with major problems in a systematic manner.

ASHOK SHINDE,

via [www.indiatoday.in](http://www.indiatoday.in)

**30**  
YEARS  
AGO IN  
INDIA  
TODAY

JANUARY 16-31, 1980

## A Triumphant Return

The golden rays of the winter sun bathed the schoolchildren rehearsing for the Republic Day parade at Raj Path in New Delhi. The soldiers in smart uniforms marched past India Gate and policemen and women in brown uniforms took their crowd-control positions along Raj Path. Most of them were too engrossed in their drills to bother about the momentous ceremony being held simultaneously a few hundred yards away in the Rashtrapati Bhavan's plush Ashoka Hall, once the ballroom of the British Viceroys. There Mrs Indira Gandhi, 62-year-old daughter of Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru, was being sworn in as India's prime minister for the third time by India's sixth President, Sanjiva Reddy. "She could well be crowned the Empress of India," said an admirer who could not get into the hall, "considering her spectacular victory." And she looked like a queen whose lost crown was being restored to her by the nation after being banished for 34 months.

INDIRA GANDHI



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